

Cliché

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What is a Cliché?

- A cliché is an overused and worn-out expression used to convey a popular thought or idea. It is an idea or phrase which has been used so much that it is no longer interesting or effective or no longer has much meaning.

Avoid cliches in Technical Writing

- A cliché is a worn-out expression. It is one that has lost its effectiveness through overuse. Don't expect your readers to be impressed if you use a cliché, especially in creative writing because they will be reading your work to enjoy **your** powers of expression.
- This quotation by Salvador Dali neatly captures the risk of using a cliché: The first man to compare the cheeks of a young woman to a rose was obviously a poet; the first to repeat it was possibly an idiot. (Spanish painter Salvador Dali)
- Also, be aware that figurative language (especially clichés) in business writing can portray you as flippant. You don't have to use any creative-writing techniques in your business writing. They could be more damaging than beneficial, and metaphors and similes carry the most risk. But, there are benefits to be had – especially if the technique suits your business environment. You'll instinctively know your boundaries, and, if you don't, seek a second opinion before you press "Send" on any business correspondence featuring figurative language (especially a cliché).

Types of Cliches

- There are five common types of cliches. For example:
- **(1) Proverbs**
- A proverb is a short, well-known saying that states a general truth or a piece of advice. For example: A bird in the hand is worth two in the bush.
- A leopard cannot change its spots.
- **(2) Idioms**
- An idiom is commonly used expression whose meaning does not relate to the literal meaning of its word. For example: I am over the moon.
- You have a Sword of Damocles hanging over you.
- I'll take any port in a storm.
- [Read more about idioms.](#)

- **(3) Catchphrases**

- A catchphrase is a well-known term, especially one that is associated with a particular famous person.
- For example: "Come on down!" (The Price Is Right)
- "Yabba dabba doo!" (Fred Flintstone)
- "You're fired!" (Donald Trump or Alan Sugar from The Apprentice)

- **(4) Similes**

- A simile is a figure of speech which compares one thing with another to create an analogy.
- For example: This is about as much use as a chocolate teapot.
- He drinks like a fish.

- **(5) Metaphors**

- A metaphor is a figure of speech which states one thing is another to create an analogy. For example: That will put the final nail in the coffin.
- I am banging my head against a brick wall here.